Panelist Checklist for Proposal Defense

For a panelist who has not read the full proposal. Skim for 5 minutes before the talk, tick what you hear during it, and ask the suggested question for any box left empty.

Student: _____ **Date:** _____

Title: _____

Level: ☐ CMSC 190 · ☐ CMSC 200 · ☐ CMSC 300

1. Before the talk: 5-minute skim

Read only these four places. Codes in brackets match the student self-review checklist.

- ☐ **Title.** Can I tell what system, problem and context it covers? Does it avoid "A Study on" and overpromising? (H1–H6)
- ☐ **Objectives page.** Is there one aim and about 3–5 objectives with action verbs, including at least one "evaluate" objective? (C1, D1–D4)
- ☐ **Evaluation section or table.** Can I find named metrics and at least one named baseline? (F1, F2)
- ☐ **References.** Are most entries peer-reviewed, with several from the last 3–5 years? (G2, G4)

Write down one thing from the skim you want the student to explain:

_____

2. During the talk: listen for

Tick each item when you hear it. For an item left unticked, ask the question below that part.

Gap and problem

- ☐ The gap is stated as a specific unsolved problem, not just a topic. (A1)
- ☐ It is backed by evidence: named papers, systems, issue reports or the student's own measurements. (A2)
- ☐ Existing work is named, with why it falls short. (B5)
- ☐ Someone is clearly affected, and there is a reason it matters now. (B4, B6)

Ask: "In one sentence, what can't existing work do that yours will?" · "What is the most recent paper closest to yours, and how is yours different?"

Aim and objectives

- [ ] The aim is one sentence with a concrete outcome. (C1–C3)
- [ ] The objectives are things to build and things to measure, not "to study" or "to understand". (D2, D4)
- [ ] Doing all the objectives would achieve the aim. (D5)

Ask: "How will you know when objective N is done?"

Related literature

- [ ] The talk groups prior work into themes rather than listing papers one by one. (G1)
- [ ] Each group ends with a limitation that leads to the gap. (G3)

Ask: "Which of these works is your strongest competitor, and why isn't it enough?"

Methods

- [ ] The design is explained, and how it attacks the gap is clear. (E4)
- [ ] The tools, platform and datasets or workloads are named. (E2, E3)
- [ ] The student actually has access to the hardware, data and accounts needed. (A5, E5)
- [ ] A timeline fits the term. (D3)

Ask: "What part are you least sure you can build, and what is your fallback?" · "Do you already have access to that dataset or testbed?"

Evaluation

- [ ] The metrics are named, with units. (F1)
- [ ] Baselines include a common default and a state-of-the-art alternative. (F2)
- [ ] Workloads or datasets are realistic or standard benchmarks. (F3)
- [ ] Conditions vary (scale, load, failures or edge cases). (F4)
- [ ] Correctness will be checked, not just performance. (F6)
- [ ] Multiple runs and statistical tests are planned. (F8)
- [ ] The student states what the evaluation will not cover. (F11)

Ask: "What result would show your approach doesn't work?" · "Why these baselines and not X?" · "How many runs, and how will you tell a real difference from noise?"

Fit across the proposal

- [ ] The title, aim and objectives describe the same scope. (H7, I4)
- [ ] Every objective has a matching method and metric. (I1)

Ask: "Walk me from objective 3 to the experiment that tests it."

3. Red flags

Any one of these usually calls for a major revision.

- [ ] The student cannot state the gap in one sentence when asked.
- [ ] Very similar recent work exists and the student doesn't know about it.
- [ ] There is no baseline, or the only comparison is "before vs. after" the student's own system.
- [ ] The evaluation is only a user satisfaction survey, for a problem that is about performance or correctness.
- [ ] It depends on hardware, data or access the student does not have and has no plan to get.
- [ ] The objectives describe a product to build, with no research question to answer.
- [ ] The title or aim promises much more than the objectives deliver.

4. Verdict

Rate each part 1–5 (1 = missing, 3 = adequate, 5 = excellent).

Part	Rating (1–5)	Main comment
Gap and problem		
Aim and objectives		
Related literature		
Methods and feasibility		
Evaluation		

Part	Rating (1–5)	Main comment
Presentation and answers		

Recommendation: ☐ Approve · ☐ Approve with minor revisions · ☐ Major revisions · ☐ Re-defend

Top 3 required revisions:

1.
2.
3.